The Face of Crime in Prime Time: Evidence from Law and Order*

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Abstract

Race, gender, and crime are inextricably linked in people's minds. These linkages exist in part because of what is shown on television. We investigate the extent to which popular television programming perpetuates these stereotypical linkages. We tally the race and gender of criminals and victims in three popular series of the most successful criminal procedural franchise on television—Law & Order. Data from episodes of *Special Victims Unit* and *Criminal Intent*, and seven seasons of the *Original* series reveal that blacks are underrepresented as criminals and victims, while women are overrepresented as criminals, compared with the historical crime records we collected. Underrepresentation of blacks is especially dramatic, with the percentages of blacks among violent-crime arrestees and serious-violent-crime victims nearly 400% and 200%, respectively, of the corresponding percentages on the shows.

*Data and scripts behind the analysis presented here can be downloaded at: https://github.com/notnews/face_of_crime.

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Offensive portrayals of African Americans on entertainment shows have long been the norm in the US. For instance, minstrel shows, popular in the 19th century and the first half of the 20th century, regularly portrayed African Americans as lazy and dim-witted (Dates and Barlow 1993; Toll 1974). More recently, Entman and Rojecki (2001) found that 56% of blacks in the media were portrayed as violent compared to 11% of the whites.

There is good reason to think that these offensive portrayals reinforce negative stereotypes of African Americans. For at least some people likely take these portrayals as representative of African Americans (see Punyanunt-Carter 2008). Correspondingly, research suggests that belief in aversive racial stereotypes is associated with exposure to television programming (Busselle and Crandall 2002; Entman and Rojecki 2001; Armstrong and Neuendorf 1992). For instance, exposure to television news is correlated with the extent to which college students endorse that blacks are lazy (Busselle and Crandall 2002). Similarly, Armstrong and Neuendorf (1992) find that more television news the college students consumed, more likely they were to believe that blacks have lower socio-economic outcomes. (Albeit, "TV drama exposure was associated with beliefs that Black Americans had a relatively higher socio-economic standing.") A more comprehensive study of how blacks are portrayed in the media by Entman and Rojecki (2001) reached similar conclusions—exposure to nonfictional portrayals of African Americans is associated with negative stereotypes of blacks.

Television's role in perpetuating negative stereotypes is worrisome because of how consequential stereotypes are in shaping attitudes, preferences, and behavior. Much research shows that racial stereotypes shape political attitudes (see, for e.g., Sniderman and Piazza

1995; Hurwitz and Peffley 1997; Peffley et al. 1997; Dixon 2006) and affect economic behavior (see, for e.g., Bertrand and Mullainathan 2004).

Given the concern, numerous researchers study how blacks are covered on various television programs (for e.g., Entman and Rojecki 2001; Eschholz et al. 2004). One particular focus of the effort—given blacks are stereotyped as violent and criminal, and given the impact such stereotypes may have on policy consequential attitudes related to punitiveness—has been on describing the extent to which blacks are overrepresented as criminals, especially as violent criminals.

Studies on the extent to which blacks are overrepresented in crime news or other programming about crime suggest that the bias is generally small but very variable—some studies document a modest anti-black bias in some news programs in some areas of the country (Gilliam et al. 1996), while others document a large anti-white bias (when compared to criminal arrest data, which are likely biased in favor of whites) (Chiricos and Eschholz 2002; Dixon and Linz 2000; Eschholz et al. 2004) (see Table 1).

In this paper, we add to this body of work. We tally the gender and race of criminals and victims depicted in three popular series of the criminal procedural, Law & Order. Compared to the arrest and victimization records we collected, all three series underrepresent blacks as criminals and victims and overrepresent women as criminals.

Table 1: Racial distribution of perpetrators and victims in earlier television studies

Region	Period	Media	Finding	Citation
Hampton Roads, Virginia	Jan. 3-31, 2011	Local TV News	Perpetrators: 50.7% Blacks (Violent Crime), 75% Whites (White Collar Crime), 75.9% Blacks (General Crime) (Graph 4) Victims: 78.3% White (Violent Crime), 82.1% Whites (General Crime) (Graph 5)	Agarwal et al. (2011)
National	1994–1997, 2000	Network News	Perpetrators: All Crime: 71% White (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 27% Blacks (vs. 30% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 4) Violent Crime: 48% White (vs. 56% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks (vs. 42% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 5) Victims: All Crime: 51% White (vs. 28% in Uniform Crime Reports), 30% Blacks (vs. 48% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 6)	Dixon et al. (2003)
National	2002–2003	Local TV News	Perpetrator (All Crime): 26.82% White, 21.06% Black, 42.27% Not Indicated Victim (All Crime): 27.88% White, 9.24% Black, 56.97% Not Indicated (Table 1)	Bjornstrom et al. (2010)
National	2000–2001	NYPD Blue and Law and Order	NYPD Blue: Offender: 50% Whites (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks, 11% Violent Off./Sus. 43% (black) 46% (white) 10% Law and Order Figures don't add up to 100. (Table 1)	Eschholz et al. (2004)
Washington, D.C.	May and June 2005	Local TV News	Perpetrators: Violent Crime: 9% Whites, 32% Blacks, 51% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 14% Whites, 29% Blacks, 50% Unrevealed Victims: Violent Crime: 15% White, 10% Blacks, 72% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 3% White, 7% Blacks, 83% Unrevealed	Gross (2006)
Los Angeles	1995–1996	Local TV News	All Perpetrators: 37% Black (versus 21% in California Department of Justice Criminal Profile or CDJCP), 21% (versus 28% in CDJCP) (Table 4) Felons: 44% Black (versus 25% in CDJCP), 18% (versus 23% in CDJCP) (Table 5)	Dixon and Linz (2000)
Los Angeles	1993–1994	Local TV News (KABC)	No commensurate numbers, except: 40% where race identified (purportedly across all crime stories). Where race identified in violent crime stories: 45% White and in non-violent crime: 75% white. Blacks actual crime rate: 2.8 * share of population. Coverage: 3.2 * share of population. (Assuming the coverage is estimated as percentage where race identified and not as percentage of total mentions) (Figure 2) Non-violent crime: Whites overrepresented by nearly 400% (see Figure 3)	Gilliam et al. (1996)
Orlando	1998	Local TV News	All Crime: 18% Black (Versus 42% Arrest Rate), 65% White (Versus 58% Arrest Rate) (Table 3) Violent Crime: 20% Black (Versus 49% Arrest Rate), 61% White (Versus 51% Arrest Rate)(Table 3)	Chiricos and Eschholz (2002)

Learning from Television

Mass media is an important part of the information environment for many people. Thus, what is covered in the media tends to affect what people believe (Gerbner et al. 1986; Shanahan and Morgan 1999). For instance, exposure to more vivid violent media causes people to think that crime and police immorality are more common in the real world (Riddle 2010). Similarly, the extent to which a topic is covered on television news affects how important people think it is (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Iyengar and Kinder 2010; Iyengar 1990).

Similar mechanism likely holds when someone watches one of the tens of hundreds of crime dramas on television. A person watching a crime drama, aware of its fictional nature, may still inadvertently think that the drama accurately 'mirrors' society. For instance, people perceive negative personality traits of African Americans portrayed on television as true to life (Punyanunt-Carter 2008). These inference are liable to be encouraged by prior interpretation and acceptance of flawed—because they are imprecise—statements such as 'art reflects life' as true.

Increasingly common mass-media tropes such as realism in depiction and explicit statements designed to cue realism may also increase the chances that people take fictional portrayals as reasonably accurate depictions of reality. As a case in point, all Law & Order *Special Victims Unit* series episodes start with the statement: "...In New York City, the dedicated detectives who investigate these vicious felonies are members of an elite squad known as the Special Victims Unit. These are their stories." It is not unreasonable to think

that some people listening to the statement may come to think that the crimes covered in the drama represent a broad, perhaps representative, set of all "sexually based crimes."

Besides learning about the extent of crime and what kind of crime is prevalent from television, people may also learn associations between kinds of people and criminal activity, especially when people involved are (superficially) distinctive—say, in the color of their skin. The logic goes that if certain kinds of people are frequently shown as perpetrators of crime, people may come to believe that as large a share of perpetrators belongs to that group. By the same token, over-representation of certain groups as victims may promote misleading views of what populations are the most vulnerable to crime.

Data and Measurement

The data are from three Law & Order series: Original Law & Order series (Original), Law & Order: Special Victims Unit (SVU), and Law & Order: Criminal Intent (Criminal Intent). All the three shows are police procedurals set in New York City. Criminal Intent, which ran between 2001–2011, purportedly follows detectives of the 'Major Case Squad,' a division of the New York Police Department (NYPD) focused on solving major crimes against rich, famous, or important people. Meanwhile SVU, which has been on television since 1999, purportedly follows detectives of the NYPD division devoted to handling "sexually based offenses," the 'Special Victims Unit.'

All three shows have enjoyed great success.

For the Original series, we only have data from Seasons 1 and 2 (1990–1991) and

Seasons 16–20 (2005–2010).[1] In all, we have data from 151 shows. For CI, we have data on 194 shows aired across its 10 seasons, spanning 2001–2011. And for SVU, we have data on 386 shows from seasons 1–17, broadcast between 1999 and 2016. In all, across the three series, we have data from 731 shows, featuring 1,578 victims of crime, and 1,117 criminals. We coded the race and gender of all criminals and victims whose race and gender was identified.

We define criminals as characters whose guilt is very clearly indicated; our definition includes characters not convicted or even indicted for a crime. In line with the law, active instigators and financiers of crime were coded as criminals. We marked attempted crimes as such. Lastly, we focus on 'major' crimes, excluding infractions such as failing to comply with court orders.

We coded victims' and criminals' race as white, black, Asian, or Hispanic, following the general census guidelines.[2] Characters of Middle-Eastern descent were coded as white, but a note marking their specific background was included in the data. And under 'Hispanics,' we included non-Hispanic Latinos such as Brazilians.

In addition to the data on the race and gender of the victims and the criminals from the shows, we collected data on a few baselines. From the 1990, 2000, and 2010 census, we collected data on the percentage of whites, blacks, and men in the US and in New York City. Like Dixon and Linz (2000), from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Report (UCR), we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and men arrested for *All Crimes*, *Violent Crimes*, and *Sexually Based Crimes*. From New York Police Department's

[1] The choice of the seasons is a reflection of what was available on streaming on Amazon Instant as of July, 2016.

[2] http://www.census.gov/topics/population/race/about.html

Crime and Enforcement Activity in New York City Report (NYPD),[3] we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and Hispanics who were suspected of (and were victims of) murder, rape, assault and robbery each year between 2008 and 2015. Lastly, from the Bureau of Justice Statistics' National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS) (Powers 2016; Victimization 1998), we gathered data on the race and gender of victims of crime.

The UCR data on race of alleged criminals is available for 1995–2015. In UCR, race is split into white, black, American Indian or Alaskan Native, Asian, and Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander. The totals in these categories include Hispanics. Data on Hispanic background only began to be collected in 2013, and even then the race totals are not split by Hispanic ethnicity. Not separating out Hispanics naturally inflates the numbers for whites and blacks. But the inflation for blacks is quite modest. Nearly 93% of Hispanics self-identify as whites (Steffensmeier et al. 2011). And accounting for Hispanics changes the percentage of blacks rape and assault by generally no more than a couple of percentage points (see figure 4, Steffensmeier et al. 2011).[4] Thus, for the main analyses, which focus on representation of blacks and Hispanics, we utilize unadjusted numbers for blacks from UCR.

In UCR, 28 types of crimes are split into two categories: *Violent Crime* and *Property Crime*. *Violent Crime* includes murder and non-negligent manslaughter, rape, robbery, and aggravated assault. And *Property Crime* includes burglary, larceny-theft, motor vehicle theft, and arson. We collected data on the percentage of people arrested by race (white and black) and gender (male) for all crimes, violent crimes, as well as arrested for three of the

[3] http://www.nyc.gov/html/nypd/html/analysis_and_planning/crime_and_enforcement_activity.shtml

[4] Steffensmeier et al. (2011) adjust UCR data by leveraging arrest data from California and New York, where arrest data includes Hispanics.

most common offenses shown in the Law & Order shows: homicides, rapes, and assaults. (661 of 731 shows or just over 90% of the shows included in our data featured a rape, murder, or assault.)

Victim data from the NCVS covers the period between 1993–2014. Racial data in the NCVS can be gathered with Hispanics included in the category totals, and without. We collected both kinds of data, but focus on data that more closely matches our data for Law & Order, and separates out Hispanics.

Like the UCR, the NCVS aggregates various crimes into categories. In NCVS, however, the categories are *Violent Victimization* and *Serious Violent Victimization*. Both account for victims of rape, sexual assault, and robbery. *Violent Victimization*, however, tallies all types of assault, while *Serious Violent Victimization* only tallies aggravated assaults. Therefore, *Serious Violent Victimization* is the closest to the *Violent Crime* category in the UCR. Hence, we use data from that category. In addition, we also collect data for two specific offenses: rape/sexual assault and aggravated assault. Given that the NCVS data comes from interviews with victims, there is naturally no data on murders. Data on the race and gender of murder victims comes from UCR.[5]

[5]Since homicides almost always lead to the discovery of the bodies of victims, data on their gender and race are usually present. In 2015, for instance, there were 13,455 homicide victims. Of those, 29 (0.2 percent) were of an unknown gender. Thus, for data about gender of homicide victims, the percentages we use are the same offered by the UCR, which are calculated on the total of homicide victims, even the ones whose gender is unknown as that has a negligible impact on the final numbers. For instance, if we include victims with unknown gender—which is done by UCR—78.8 percent of all victims were male. Excluding those, the percentage changes to 79.0 percent. For perpetrators, we also use percentages offered by the UCR, but there is a high number of perpetrators unknown gender. Therefore, the percentages are based on the total of perpetrators whose gender is known.

Results

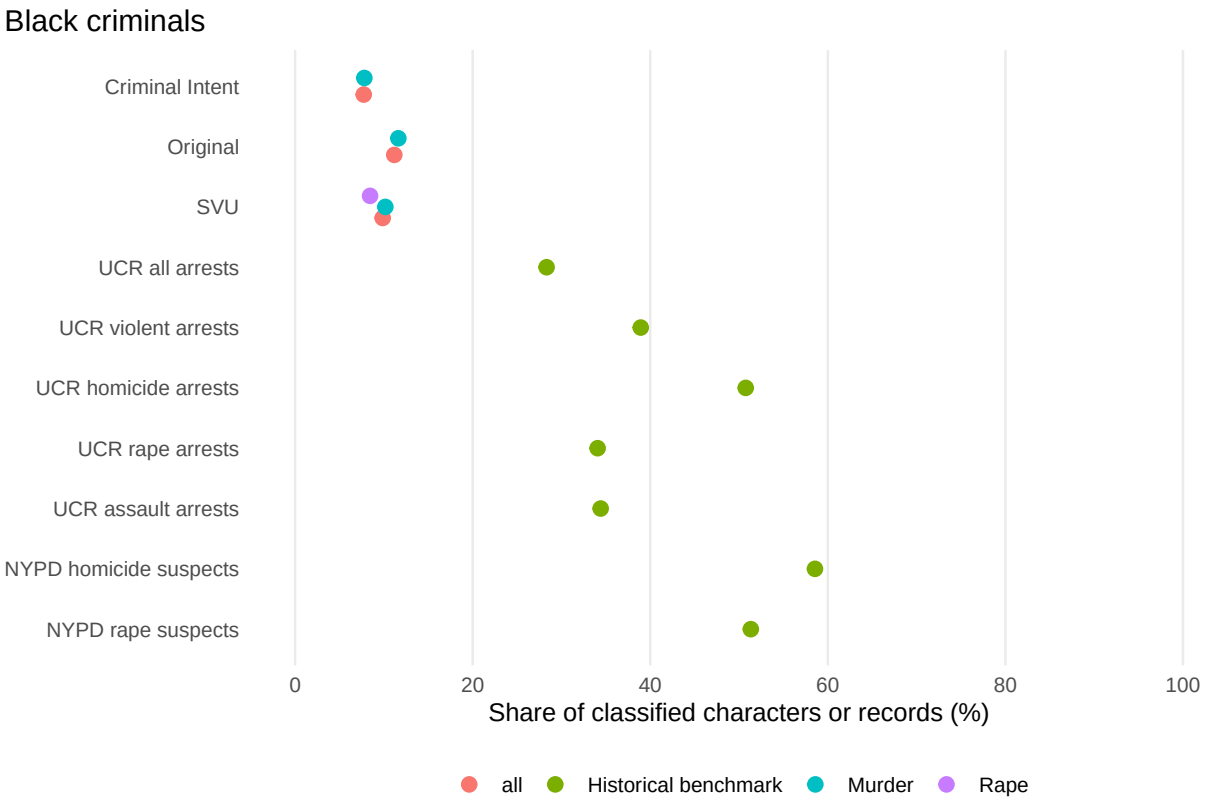
To study how racial and gender breakdown of criminals and victims in Law & Order compares to 'the real world,' we compare the percentage of black and female criminals and victims on the three Law & Order shows to a variety of baselines. In the main text, we describe the percentage of black and female criminals and victims by show, same percentages for episodes featuring murder, and SVU episodes featuring rape. (Criminal Intent and Original had fewer than 10 episodes each where rape was one of the crimes.) We compare these to average percentage of black, Hispanic, and female criminals for all crimes, rape, and murder from the UCR, and percentage of black and female victims for murder, rape, and serious violent crimes over the years available in our records. A series of graphs and tables in SI 1 and SI 2 break data down by year, and provide other baselines like data from the census that we don't include in the main text.

As Figure 1 and Figure 2 show, criminals on all three shows were overwhelmingly white. Between 81.7% and 86.4% of the criminals in each show were white. The figures also illustrate that blacks and Hispanics are underrepresented as criminals relative to the arrest records we collected. The black criminal shares were 7.7% in Criminal Intent, 9.9% in SVU, and 11.2% in Original, compared with nearly 39% of violent-crime arrests in the UCR (see Figure 1).

Looking at percentage of black criminals by year—all episodes broadcast in a year; generally includes episodes from two seasons—we see no discernible pattern (see Figure SI 1.1 and Table SI 2.2). However, one fact deserves closer attention. The FBI approved a

broader definition of rape in 2011 and began collecting UCR data under it in 2013. The new definition for the first time accounted for male rape. As we can see in Table SI 2.2, the percentage of rape arrestees who are black changes only modestly around that time. The gap between the shows and the arrest records remains large.

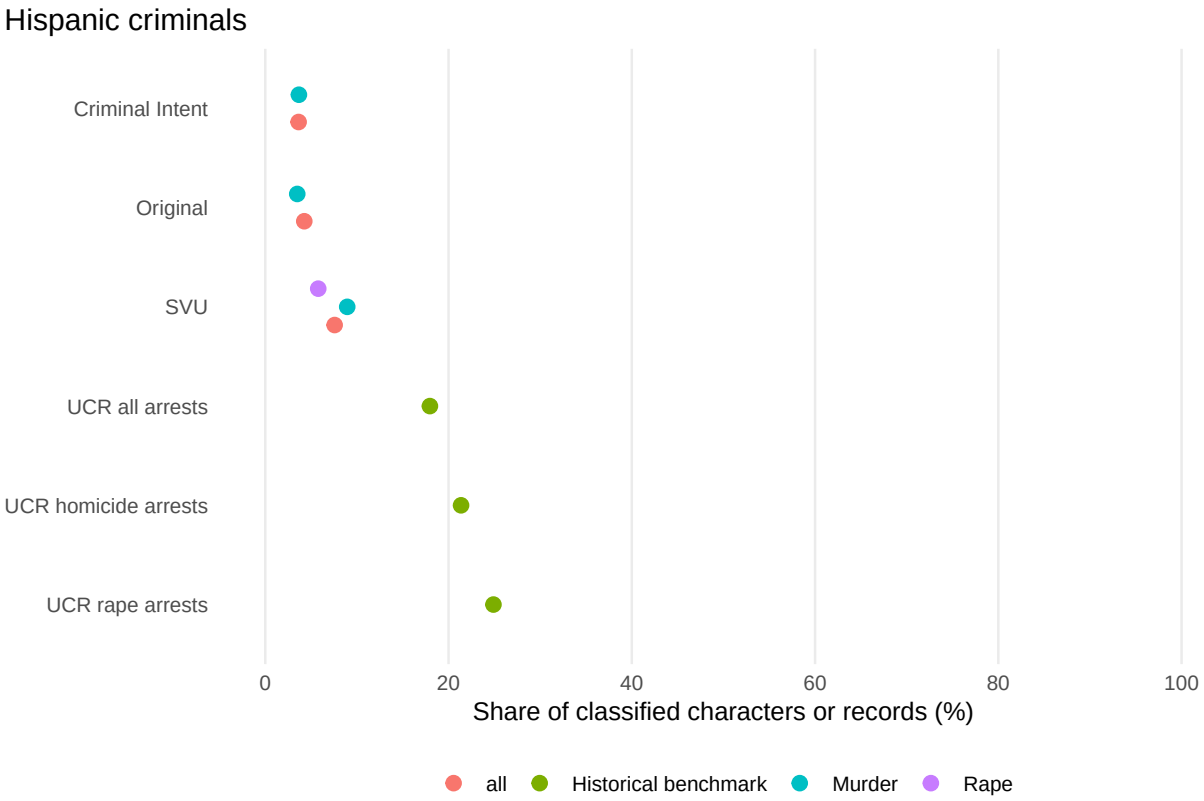
Figure 1: Share of Black Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

Not only were the perpetrators of crime overwhelmingly white, so were the victims (see Figure 3). Between 73.4% and 82.1% of the victims depicted in the three shows were white. Compared to Law & Order, where about 10 percent of the victims were black, the average percentage of black victims of a serious violent crime between 1999 and 2014 was

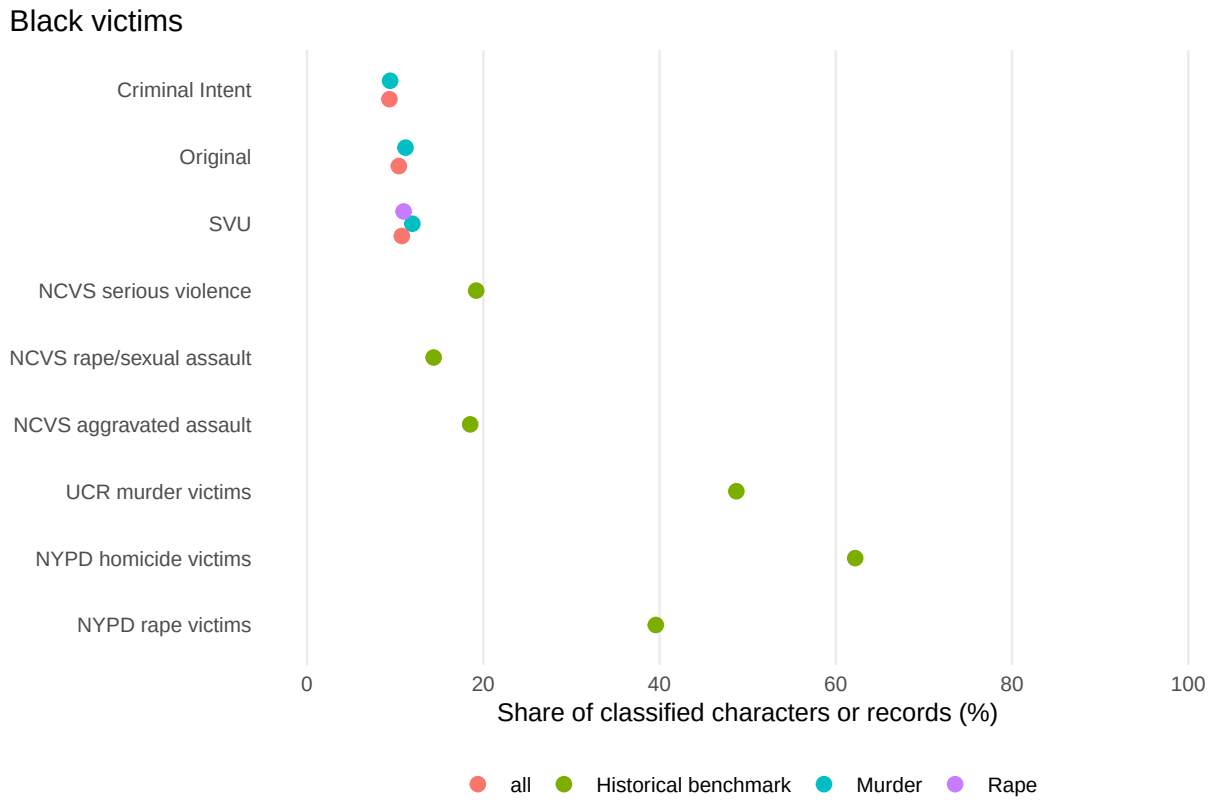
Figure 2: Share of Hispanic Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

19.8%. The corresponding number for victims of sexual assault was 15.2%, for aggravated assault, 19.4%, and for murder, 48.7% (see Figure 3). Splitting the data by year and tallying the percentage of victims who were black revealed no discernible time trend across shows (see Figure SI 1.2 and Table SI 2.1).

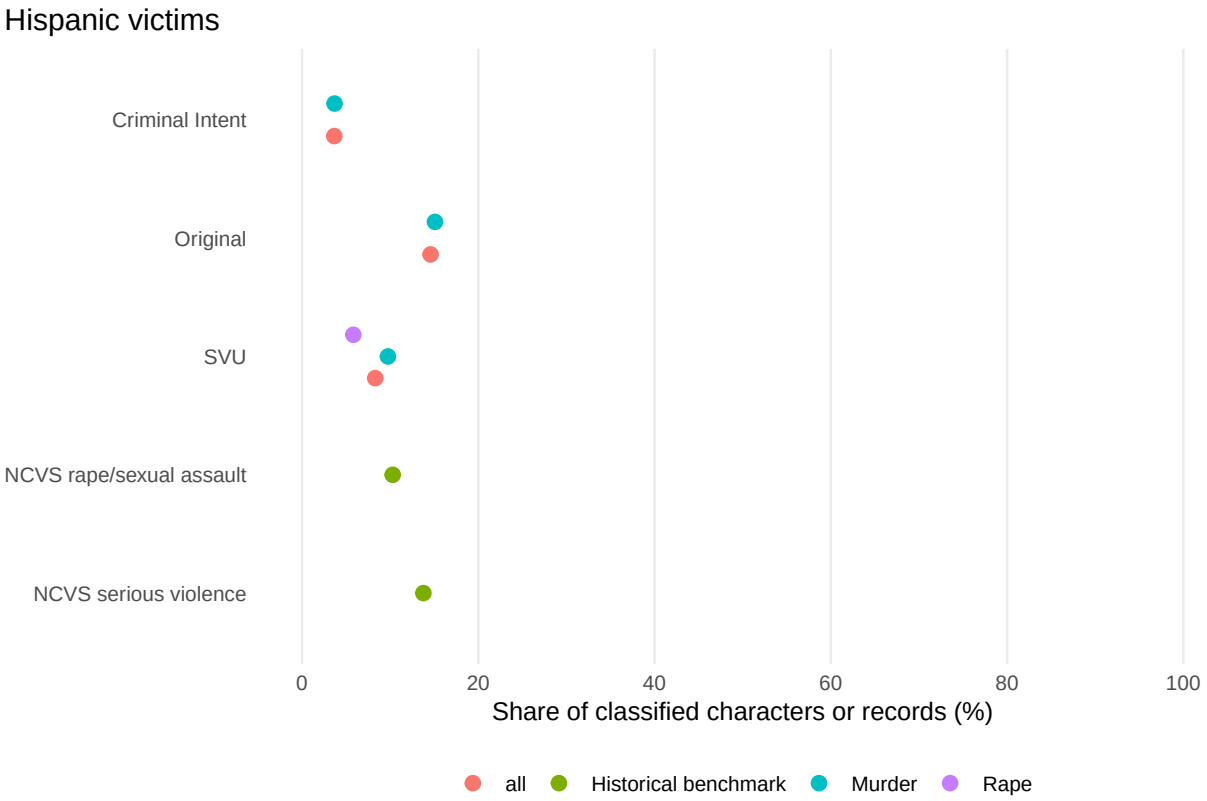
Figure 3: Share of Black Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

Moving to gender, between 26.8% and 31.9% of the criminals were women across the three shows (see Figure 5). Once again, there was no distinct over time pattern in percentage of criminals who were women across the three shows (see Figure SI 1.3 and Table SI 2.4). The percentage of women among those arrested in the UCR is lower—about 11% of homicide

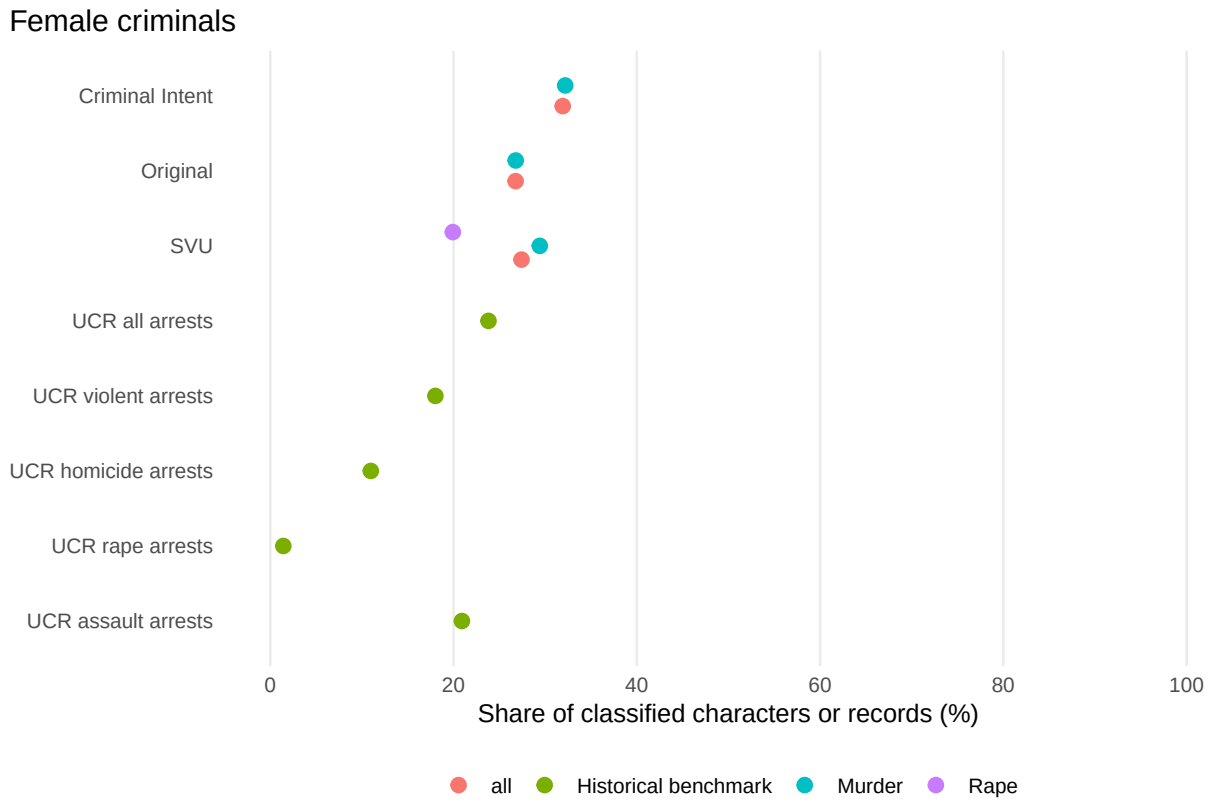
Figure 4: Share of Hispanic Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

arrestees, 1%–3% of rape arrestees, and 17%–20% of those arrested for a violent crime. The rape-arrest series changes after the FBI's revised definition took effect in 2013 (Table SI 2.4).

Figure 5: Share of Female Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World

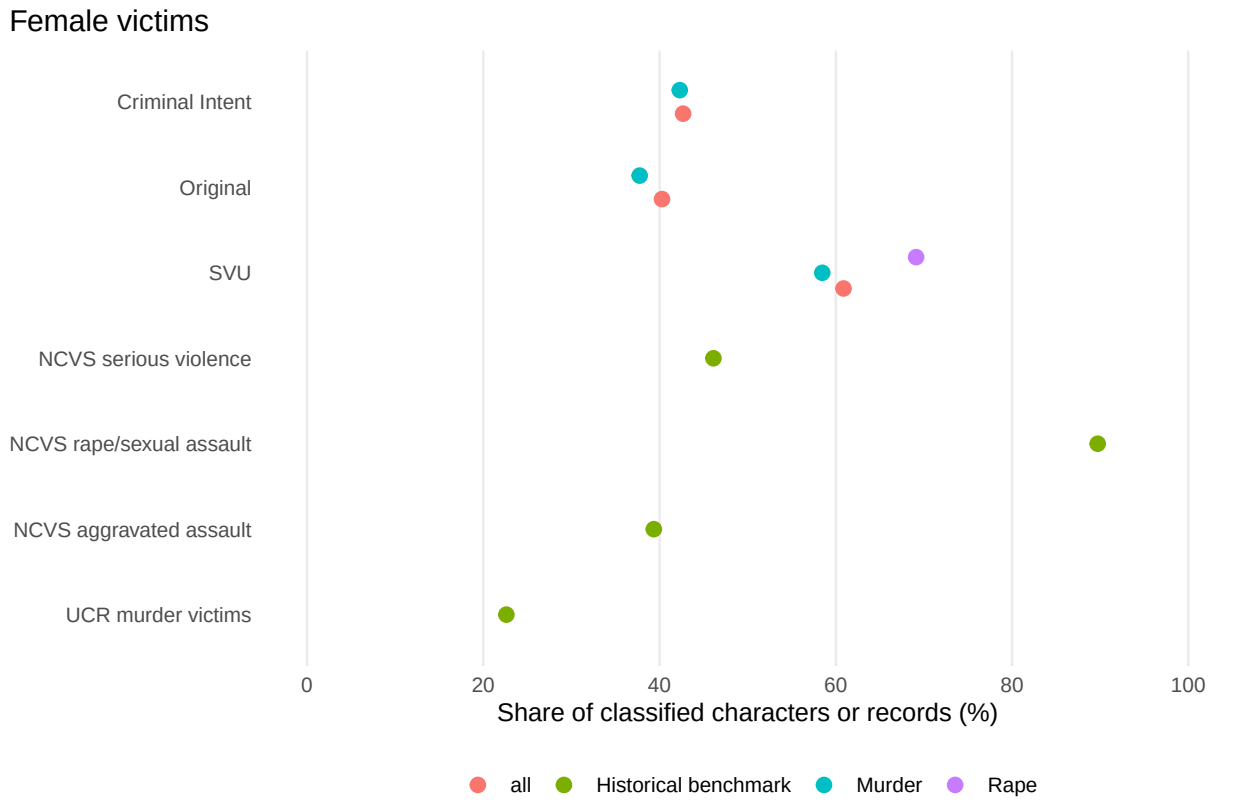


Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

When we looked at the gender of victims, there was an expected sizable variation across shows, with female victims constituting roughly 40% of all the victims on Criminal Intent and Original and just over 60% on SVU (see Figure 6). Except for CI, where there appears to be a downward trend post 2005, there were no discernible time trends (see Figure SI 1.4 and Table SI 2.3). In the NCVS, the percentage of victims of serious violent crime who are women is 46.1%, while the percentage of female victims of rape or sexual assault

is a distressing 89.7%; in the UCR, the percentage of female murder victims is 22.6%. As is clear in Figure 6, SVU understates the percentage of female rape victims, and all three shows show a much larger proportion of female murder victims than in the UCR.

Figure 6: Share of Female Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



Discussion

Popular television is our bay window to the world. What we see on television likely has a sizable influence on how we think about the world. In particular, television programming likely influences how we think about crime, how common we think it is, especially in our

communities, who we think perpetrates it, the reasons why criminals do what they do, who the victims are, the efficacy of the police and judicial systems, among other things.

In this essay, we shed light on whether a popular police procedural perpetuates adversarial stereotypes about blacks, and in doing so shed light on racial and gender imbalance in portrayal of criminals and victims. In line with other evidence (see Table 1), we find that contrary to worries about overrepresentation of blacks as criminals, whites are overrepresented as perpetrators and, to a smaller degree, as victims, compared with the records we collected. We also find that women are overrepresented as criminals. These imbalances likely affect people's perceptions of who the criminals and victims are. For instance, naive but avid viewers of Law & Order may come to believe that the share of perpetrators and victims of crime who are white is substantially higher than it is. This, in turn, may shape their views about crime and policies that are likely to be most efficacious in reducing crime. For instance, they may become persuaded that greater policing of white neighborhoods is needed. Similar such shaping of policy consequential attitudes is easy to fathom.

Beyond its potential impact on policy attitude consequential beliefs, the racial and gender asymmetries also hint at the beliefs and motives of the writers and producers of the show. One potential reason for asymmetries may be that writers and producers are politically liberal. In particular, the writers and producers may have reasoned that the audience is liable to swap $p(\text{black}|\text{criminal})$ with $p(\text{criminal}|\text{black})$ (see, for instance, Bordalo et al. Forthcoming; Ahler and Sood 2016) and altered race to address such concerns. Or the profit motive may have weighed in on their decisions. By exaggerating the share of white

victims and criminals, they may have thought that they would be able to instill greater fear (and thrill) in the white audience members. Or it may be something else entirely. Whatever the genesis of the decisions about race and gender of criminals and victims, our purpose in this essay was to merely describe the decisions. And that the racial and gender breakdown of victims and criminals on the show goes against conventional wisdom is likely worthy of notice.

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Supporting Information

SI 1 Percentage of Black and Female Criminals and Victims in Law & Order By Year

Figure SI 1.1: Race of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

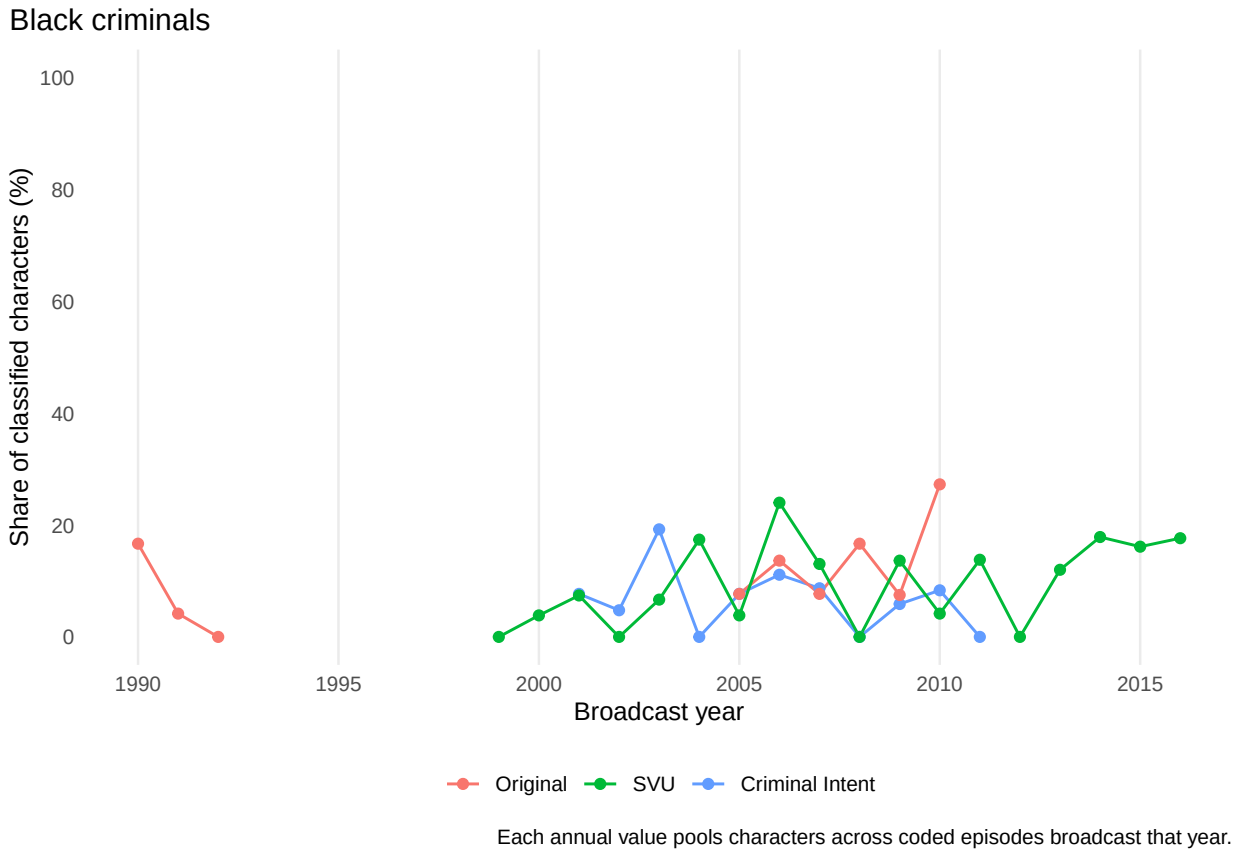


Figure SI 1.2: Race of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

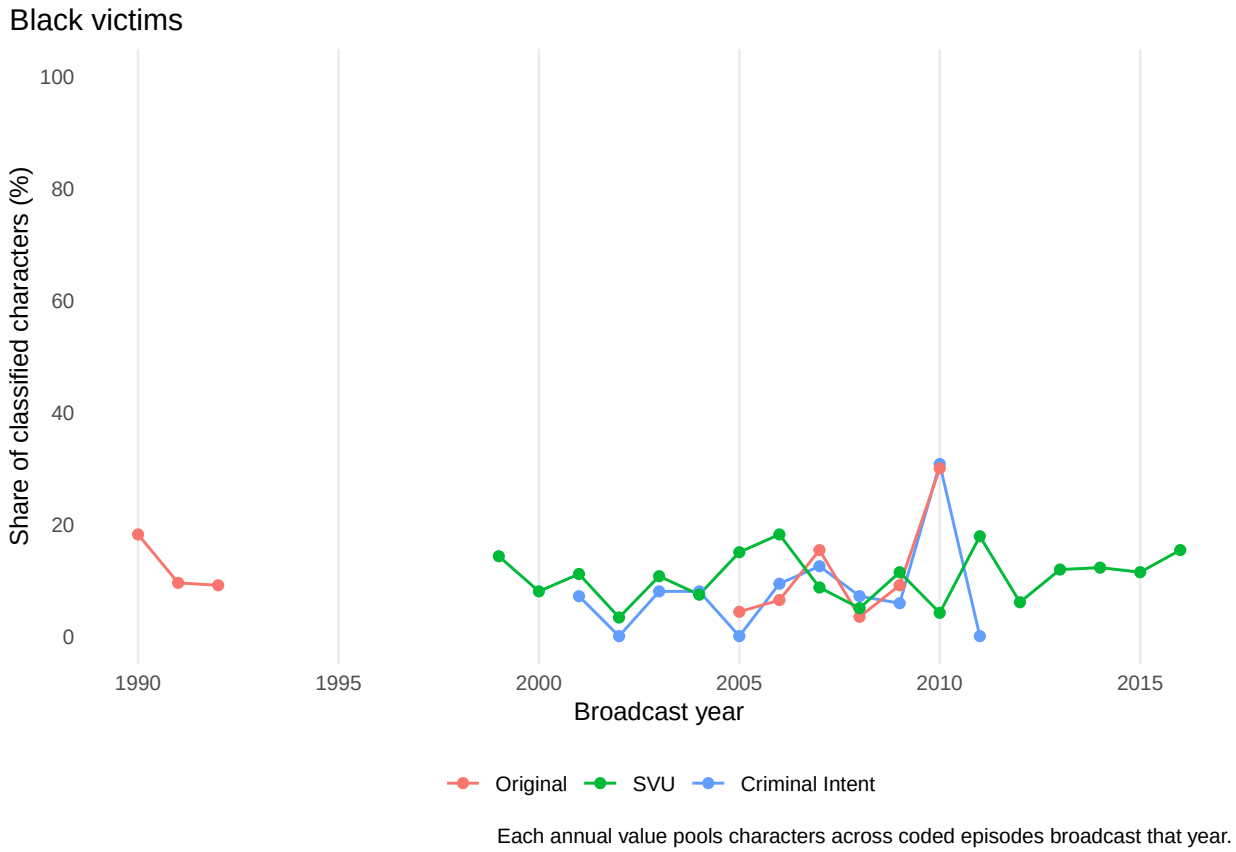


Figure SI 1.3: Gender of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

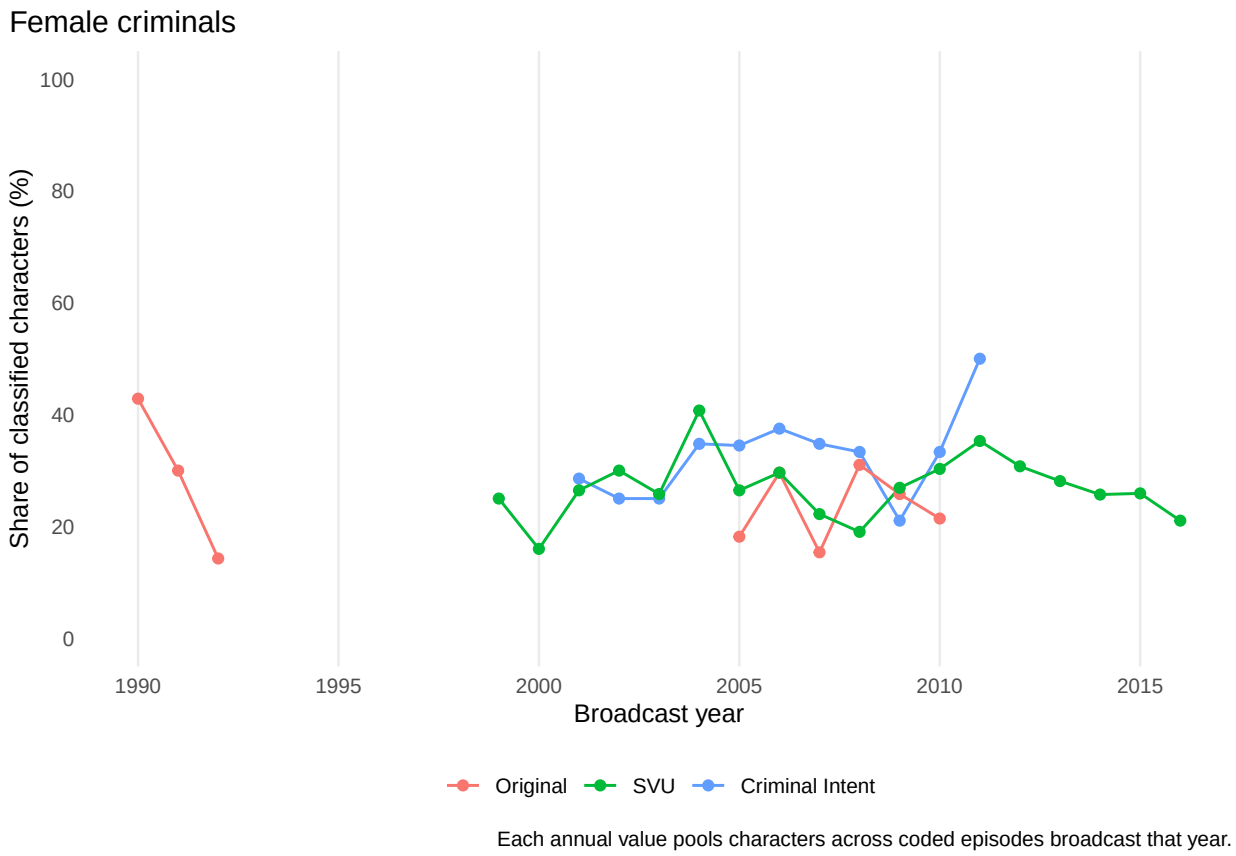
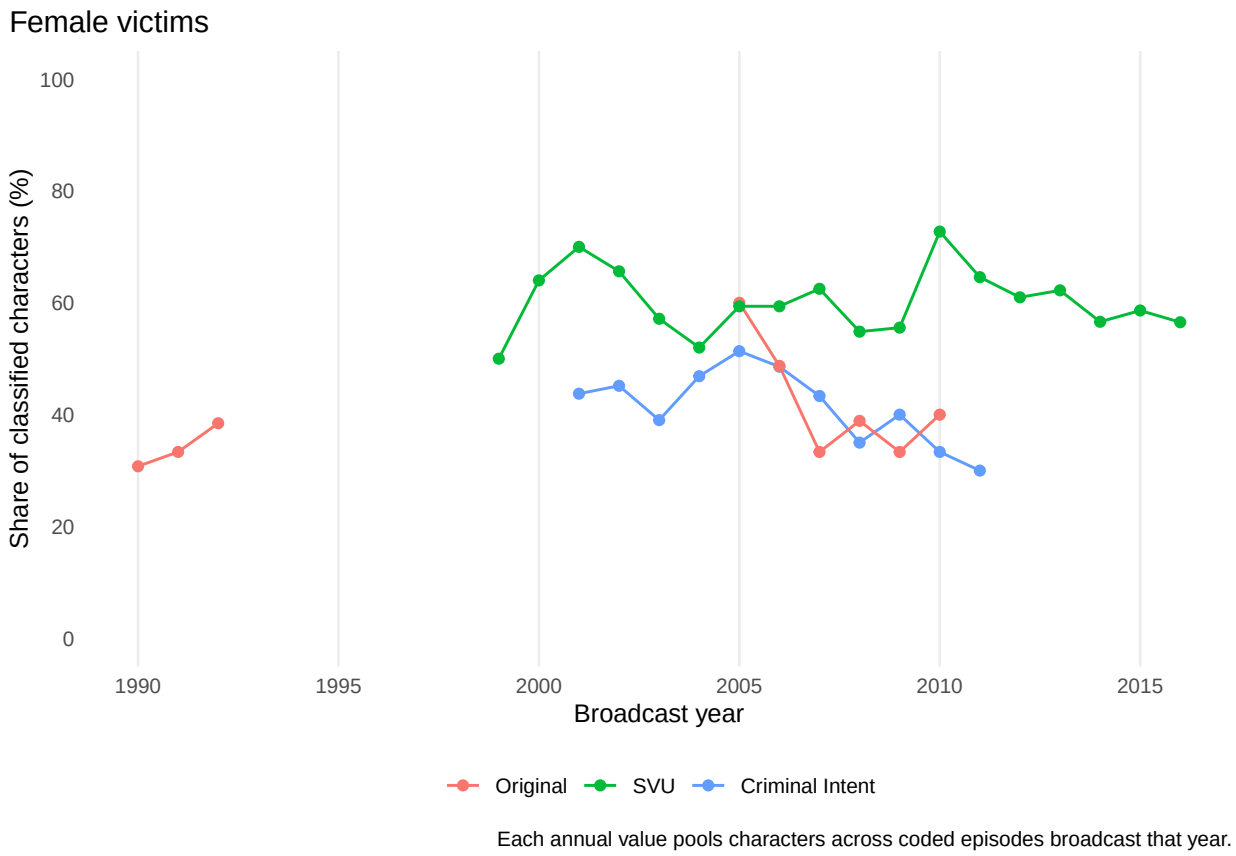


Figure SI 1.4: Gender of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



SI 2 Sex and Race of Criminals and Victims in Law & Order and the Real World

Table SI 2.1: Annual share of black victim characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	NCVS serious violence	NCVS rape/sexual assault	NCVS aggravated assault	UCR murder victims	NYPD homicide victims	NYPD rape victims	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	18.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	9.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	9.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	14.3	21.4	16.4	19.0	46.0	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	8.0	16.0	9.2	13.8	48.0	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.1	–	11.1	19.5	22.1	18.9	47.0	–	–	–	–
2002	0.0	–	3.3	22.1	27.3	22.2	48.0	–	–	–	–
2003	8.0	–	10.7	15.2	7.4	12.6	48.0	–	–	–	–
2004	8.0	–	7.4	20.0	19.1	16.7	47.0	–	–	–	–
2005	0.0	4.3	15.0	20.7	24.9	21.8	48.0	–	–	–	–
2006	9.4	6.5	18.2	21.8	18.9	27.8	50.0	–	–	–	–
2007	12.5	15.4	8.7	24.9	6.3	24.2	49.0	–	–	–	–
2008	7.1	3.4	5.0	19.2	16.3	16.4	48.0	62.1	40.6	–	–
2009	5.9	9.1	11.4	26.3	12.7	24.2	48.0	57.6	40.5	–	–
2010	30.8	30.0	4.2	19.1	12.2	21.1	50.0	67.0	40.9	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	17.9	18.2	14.7	18.0	50.0	61.8	36.8	–	–
2012	–	–	6.1	17.9	5.6	18.6	51.0	60.1	37.9	–	–
2013	–	–	11.9	16.5	7.7	20.6	51.0	62.9	40.8	–	–
2014	–	–	12.2	17.3	22.6	15.1	51.0	62.4	39.7	–	–
2015	–	–	11.4	–	–	–	52.0	63.7	39.4	–	–
2016	–	–	15.4	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.2: Annual share of black criminal characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	UCR all arrests	UCR violent arrests	UCR homicide arrests	UCR rape arrests	UCR assault arrests	NYPD homicide suspects	NYPD rape suspects	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	16.7	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	4.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	0.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	0.0	28.6	38.7	51.8	36.2	34.8	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	3.8	27.9	37.8	48.8	34.1	34.0	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.7	–	7.4	28.1	37.6	48.7	34.8	33.7	–	–	–	–
2002	4.8	–	0.0	26.9	38.0	50.0	34.0	34.2	–	–	–	–
2003	19.2	–	6.7	27.0	37.2	48.5	33.3	33.0	–	–	–	–
2004	0.0	–	17.4	26.8	36.9	47.2	31.9	32.7	–	–	–	–
2005	7.7	7.7	3.8	27.8	38.8	48.6	32.7	34.3	–	–	–	–
2006	11.1	13.6	24.0	28.0	39.3	50.9	32.5	34.5	–	–	–	–
2007	8.7	7.7	13.0	28.2	39.0	50.4	33.5	33.7	–	–	–	–
2008	0.0	16.7	0.0	28.3	39.4	50.1	32.2	34.2	60.8	52.8	–	–
2009	5.9	7.5	13.6	28.3	38.9	49.3	32.5	33.9	59.8	52.4	–	–
2010	8.3	27.3	4.2	28.0	38.1	48.7	31.8	33.5	60.9	52.6	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	13.8	28.4	38.3	49.7	32.9	33.6	56.3	48.8	–	–
2012	–	–	0.0	28.1	38.5	49.4	32.5	34.1	53.7	50.5	–	–
2013	–	–	12.0	28.3	38.7	52.2	31.3	33.9	55.0	53.0	–	–
2014	–	–	17.9	27.8	37.7	51.3	29.9	33.1	59.8	49.3	–	–
2015	–	–	16.1	26.6	36.4	51.1	28.2	32.1	62.1	51.2	–	–
2016	–	–	17.6	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.3: Annual share of female victim characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	NCVS serious violence	NCVS rape/sexual assault	NCVS aggravated assault	UCR murder victims	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	30.8	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	33.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	38.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	50.0	48.2	93.3	39.2	24.0	–	–
2000	–	–	64.0	38.1	96.0	27.1	24.0	50.9	52.6
2001	43.8	–	70.0	49.0	90.1	41.1	24.0	–	–
2002	45.2	–	65.6	49.3	86.6	44.0	23.0	–	–
2003	39.0	–	57.1	50.7	94.0	41.6	22.0	–	–
2004	46.9	–	52.0	45.4	97.6	37.1	22.0	–	–
2005	51.4	60.0	59.4	40.1	92.7	39.3	21.0	–	–
2006	48.6	48.7	59.4	47.4	77.6	42.5	21.0	–	–
2007	43.3	33.3	62.5	46.5	95.5	39.0	22.0	–	–
2008	35.0	38.9	54.8	54.9	88.7	47.2	22.0	–	–
2009	40.0	33.3	55.6	49.4	93.5	45.0	23.0	–	–
2010	33.3	40.0	72.7	52.5	94.4	43.2	23.0	50.8	52.5
2011	30.0	–	64.6	47.5	85.7	43.0	22.0	–	–
2012	–	–	61.0	42.3	62.2	42.5	22.0	–	–
2013	–	–	62.2	49.0	88.7	39.1	22.0	–	–
2014	–	–	56.6	46.9	90.1	39.6	23.0	–	–
2015	–	–	58.6	–	–	–	21.0	–	–
2016	–	–	56.5	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.4: Annual share of female criminal characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	UCR all arrests	UCR violent arrests	UCR homicide arrests	UCR rape arrests	UCR assault arrests	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	42.9	–	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	30.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	14.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	25.0	21.8	17.0	11.4	1.3	19.7	–	–
2000	–	–	16.0	22.2	17.4	10.6	1.1	20.1	50.9	52.6
2001	28.6	–	26.5	22.5	17.3	12.5	1.2	20.1	–	–
2002	25.0	–	30.0	23.0	17.4	10.8	1.4	20.2	–	–
2003	25.0	–	25.8	23.2	17.8	10.3	1.3	20.7	–	–
2004	34.8	–	40.7	23.8	17.9	11.5	1.5	20.8	–	–
2005	34.5	18.2	26.5	23.8	17.9	11.0	1.5	20.8	–	–
2006	37.5	29.6	29.6	23.7	17.8	10.9	1.3	20.7	–	–
2007	34.8	15.4	22.2	24.2	18.2	10.2	1.1	21.3	–	–
2008	33.3	31.0	19.0	24.5	18.3	10.8	1.2	21.5	–	–
2009	21.1	25.8	26.9	25.3	18.8	10.4	1.3	22.0	–	–
2010	33.3	21.4	30.3	25.5	19.5	10.9	1.1	22.6	50.8	52.5
2011	50.0	–	35.3	25.9	19.6	11.8	1.2	22.7	–	–
2012	–	–	30.8	26.2	19.9	11.3	0.9	22.9	–	–
2013	–	–	28.1	26.5	20.1	11.7	1.9	23.0	–	–
2014	–	–	25.7	26.7	20.2	11.5	2.8	23.0	–	–
2015	–	–	25.9	26.9	20.3	11.5	2.9	23.1	–	–
2016	–	–	21.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.